3.28 In the French part of the study area, accumulation rates of 290 objects/km² can be reached on the continental shelf, with plastic waste found at different depths. The majority of plastic waste found in this area originates from fishing activities, wit h ferry traffic around Corsica also representing a considerable source of waste, particularly bottles and cans thrown overboard (Gerigny et al., 2019). The presence of marine litter in increasing quantities is a serious threat to marine ecosystems, particu larly for turtles and marine mammals (risk of entanglement, suffocation by ingestion).

Biological pollution

3.29 Shipping transport is considered to be the most important vector for the import of exogenous marine species in the world, via ballast water or biofouling accumulated on the

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SOURCE: MEPC.380(80).pdf
entanglement, suffocation by ingestion).

Biological pollution

3.29 Shipping transport is considered to be the most important vector for the import of exogenous marine species in the world, via ballast water or biofouling accumulated on the surface of ships' hulls, respectively managed by IMO through the Ballast Water Management Convention and the Anti -Fouling System Convention. The semi -enclosed nature of the Mediterranean Sea and the importance of shipping traffic, particularly in its north -western basin, make it very sensitive to this risk. Invasive species can cause the restructuring of entire habitats to the detriment of native species, with the risk of reducing biological and genetic diversity within populations. However, this risk is only likely to affec t very indirectly cetacean populations in the Mediterranean.

Greenhouse gas and air pollutant emissions

3.30 Greenhouse gas emissions have a global impact and are generated by various sectors of activity, including transport. Shipping traffic contributes to this, but only to a limited extent: in 2017, 3.15% of total EU greenhouse gas emissions were attributable to international

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SOURCE: MEPC.380(80).pdf
sectors of activity, including transport. Shipping traffic contributes to this, but only to a limited extent: in 2017, 3.15% of total EU greenhouse gas emissions were attributable to international shipping. However, with a significant increase of 32% over the last 20 years and an estimated projection of 50 - 250% by 2050, despite reductions in fuel consumption, the European Parliament voted on 16 September 2020 to include shippi ng in the EU Emissions Trading Scheme (EU ETS) and to set binding standards for shipping companies to reduce their CO 2 emissions by at least 40% by 2030. Negotiations are still ongoing on the EU's Fit for 55 legislative package.

3.31 CO2 emissions from maritime transport are estimated at about 10% of the total CO 2 inventories emitted by the 21 Mediterranean countries that are signatories to the Barcelona Convention. These emissions also contribute to increased acidification and eutrophication of the marine environment.

3.32 The consequences of the increase in greenhouse gases on the marine environment

are known and include the increase in temperature and acidification of marine waters. This

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SOURCE: MEPC.380(80).pdf
the marine environment.

3.32 The consequences of the increase in greenhouse gases on the marine environment are known and include the increase in temperature and acidification of marine waters. This may have consequences for cetaceans in terms of the distribution of their prey an d their vulnerability to pathogens, which could thus find more favourable conditions for their development.
RESOLUTION MEPC.380(80) (adopted on 7 July 2023)
DESIGNATION OF THE NORTH-WESTERN MEDITERRANEAN SEA AS A PARTICULARLY SENSITIVE SEA AREAMEPC 80/17/Add.1
Annex 20, page 22

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3.33 The Mediterranean States have jointly committed, within the framework of IMO, in a landmark initiative on the greening of maritime transport. The States submitted to IMO a joint and coordinated proposal to establish an Emission Control Area for Sulphur Oxides and particulate matter (SECA) in the whole Mediterranean Sea at the seventy-eighth session of the Committee for the Protection of the Marine Environment (MEPC). The designation of this area as a SECA entails the ob ligation for all ships entering the Mediterranean to use fuel with

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SOURCE: MEPC.380(80).pdf
Committee for the Protection of the Marine Environment (MEPC). The designation of this area as a SECA entails the ob ligation for all ships entering the Mediterranean to use fuel with sulphur content not exceeding 0.10% by mass, i.e. fuel five times less polluting than the international standard in non -SECA. MEPC adopted amendments to designate the Mediterranean Sea, as a whole, as a SECA under MARPOL Annex VI, at its seventy -ninth session in 2022. The amendment is expected to enter into force on 1 May 2024, with the new sulphur limit taking effect from 1 May 2025. This new SECA will significantly improve air quality in the area and protect the health of millions of Mediterranean cit izens and their fragile environment.

Summary of groundings, collisions or spills in the area

3.34 The Mediterranean Integrated Geographic Information System for Risk Assessment and Response to Marine Pollution (MEDGIS-MAR), administered by REMPEC, lists 82 events that occurred in the study area between 1977 and 2017. However, as no data is availab le for the study area between 2002 and 2011, it is likely that some information is missing or not published.

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SOURCE: MEPC.380(80).pdf
that occurred in the study area between 1977 and 2017. However, as no data is availab le for the study area between 2002 and 2011, it is likely that some information is missing or not published.

3.35 Of the events listed, 8 resulted in the release of more than 700 tonnes of hazardous substances into the environment (6 involving oil pollution), 8 resulted in the release of between 7 and 700 tonnes, 42 resulted in the release of less than 7 tonnes of hazardous substances.

3.36 The most dramatic event for the marine environment in the area was the accident off Genoa on 11 April 1991, when an explosion followed by a fire on the Cypriot tanker MT Haven resulted in the loss of 144,000 tonnes of heavy oil at sea. In terms of media coverage, the sinking of the cruise ship Costa Concordia in 2012 is widely remembered, mainly for the loss of life, although its impact on the marine environment was limited.

3.37 In relation to collisions between ships and cetaceans, a very recent collision event can be cited. The vessel Hypatia de Alexandria, from the Balearia fleet, brushed against two

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SOURCE: MEPC.380(80).pdf
3.37 In relation to collisions between ships and cetaceans, a very recent collision event can be cited. The vessel Hypatia de Alexandria, from the Balearia fleet, brushed against two fin whales that were 15 miles off the coast of the Llobregat Delta on 26 May 2022. One of the individuals made an emergency dive about 50 m from the vessel and the other is believed to have grazed the keel of the vessel.

Measures taken to protect the area and their positive effects

3.38 The wealth and plurality of environmental issues in the study area, as already described, have prompted the coastal States or local authorities concerned to take specific protection measures by creating various marine protected areas. In total, almost 145,000 km² of the study area has a special status.

3.39 A number of measures have already been adopted by IMO including:

.1 adoption on 2 November 1973 of a Special Area (SA) covering the entire Mediterranean under Annexes I (Regulation for the Prevention of Pollution by oil) and V (Regulation for the Prevention of Pollution by garbage from ships) of the MARPOL Convention. This measure came into force on 2 October 1983;

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SOURCE: MEPC.380(80).pdf
Mediterranean under Annexes I (Regulation for the Prevention of Pollution by oil) and V (Regulation for the Prevention of Pollution by garbage from ships) of the MARPOL Convention. This measure came into force on 2 October 1983;

.2 adoption on 15 July 2011 of a PSSA for the Strait of Bonifacio by

resolution MEPC.204(62) which refers to protective measures previously adopted by resolution A.766(18) on 4 November 1993; and

.3 adoption on 16 December 2022 of the Mediterranean Sea Emission Control Area for Sulphur Oxides and Particulate Matter by resolution MEPC.361(79).

3.40 Measures have also been taken for the protection of cetaceans including

.1 International Pelagos Sanctuary - the Pelagos Agreement (November 1999) for the protection of marine mammals within the Pelagos Sanctuary entered into force on 21 February 2002, after ratification by the three concerned countries (France, Italy, Monaco). The Sanctuary covers a total are a

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SOURCE: MEPC.380(80).pdf
for the protection of marine mammals within the Pelagos Sanctuary entered into force on 21 February 2002, after ratification by the three concerned countries (France, Italy, Monaco). The Sanctuary covers a total are a of 87,500 km². The objective of the agreement is to maintain a favourable conservation status for marine mammal populations within the Sanctuary, and to this end, to monitor cetacean populations, to reinforce the application of existing legislation on certain fishing activities, to reduce pollution, to regulate tourist observation of cetaceans and to improve the dissemination of information to the public. Since November 2002, the Pelagos Sanctuary